



NSW Education Standards Authority

2025 HIGHER SCHOOL CERTIFICATE EXAMINATION

English Extension 1

**General
Instructions**

- Reading time – 10 minutes
- Working time – 2 hours
- Write using black pen

**Total marks:
50****Section I – 25 marks** (pages 2–3)

- Attempt Question 1
- Allow about 1 hour for this section

Section II – 25 marks (pages 4–9)

- Attempt Question 2
- Allow about 1 hour for this section

Section I — Common Module: Literary Worlds

25 marks

Attempt Question 1

Allow about 1 hour for this section

Answer the question on pages 2–12 of the English Extension 1 Writing Booklet. Extra writing booklets are available.

Your answer will be assessed on how well you:

- demonstrate an understanding of the ideas and values of Literary Worlds and how they are shaped and reflected in texts
 - craft a sustained composition appropriate to the question, demonstrating control of the use of language
-

Question 1 (25 marks)

Read Text 1 on page 3.

Compose a discursive response in which you extend the ideas in Text 1.

In your response, articulate your insights into how texts make meaning through the crafting of literary worlds.

Question 1 continues on page 3

Question 1 (continued)

Text 1

For me, all fiction is about prizing the logic of metaphors – which is the logic of narratives in general – over reality, which is irreducibly random and senseless.

We spend our entire lives trying to tell stories about ourselves – they’re the essence of memory. It is how we make living in this unfeeling, accidental universe tolerable. That we call such a tendency “the narrative fallacy” doesn’t mean it doesn’t also touch upon some aspect of the truth.

Some stories simply literalise their metaphors a bit more explicitly.

I’m also a translator, and translation offers a natural metaphor for how I think about writing in general.

Every act of communication is a miracle of translation.

At this moment, in this place, the shifting action potentials in my neurons cascade into certain arrangements, patterns, thoughts; they flow down my spine, branch into my arms, my fingers, until muscles twitch and thought is translated into motion; mechanical levers are pressed; electrons are rearranged; marks are made on paper.

At another time, in another place, light strikes the marks, reflects into a pair of high-precision optical instruments sculpted by nature after billions of years of random mutations; upside-down images are formed against two screens made up of millions of light-sensitive cells, which translate light into electrical pulses that go up the optic nerves, cross the chiasm^[1], down the optic tracts, and into the visual cortex, where the pulses are reassembled into letters, punctuation marks, words, sentences ... thoughts.

The entire system seems fragile, preposterous, science fictional.

Who can say if the thoughts you have in your mind as you read these words are the same thoughts I had in my mind as I typed them? We are different, you and I, and the qualia of our consciousnesses^[2] are as divergent as two stars at the ends of the universe.

And yet, whatever has been lost in translation in the long journey of my thoughts through the maze of civilisation to your mind, I think you do understand me, and you think you do understand me. Our minds managed to touch, if but briefly and imperfectly.

Does the thought not make the universe seem just a bit kinder, a bit brighter, a bit warmer and more human?

We live for such miracles.

KEN LIU

Extract from *The Paper Menagerie and Other Stories*

^[1] chiasm *intersection of pathways in the eye*

^[2] qualia of our consciousnesses *subjectivity of our thoughts*

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Scovil Galen Ghosh Literary Agency, Inc

End of Question 1

Section II — Electives

25 marks

Attempt Question 2

Allow about 1 hour for this section

Answer the question on pages 14–24 of the English Extension 1 Writing Booklet. Extra writing booklets are available.

Your answer will be assessed on how well you:

- demonstrate an understanding of the ideas and values of Literary Worlds and how they are shaped and reflected in texts
 - craft a sustained composition appropriate to the question, demonstrating control of the use of language
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Question 2 (25 marks)

Read Text 2.

How does Text 2 shape your understanding of the ways your texts ‘creatively break’ dominant assumptions in the elective you have studied?

In your response, make close reference to TWO prescribed texts from your elective and ONE other text of your own choosing.

The prescribed texts for Section II are listed on pages 5–9.

Text 2

Stories surround us like air; we breathe them in, we breathe them out. The art of being fully conscious in personal life means seeing the stories and becoming their teller, rather than letting them be the unseen forces that tell you what to do.

. . .

There are stories beneath the stories and around the stories. The recent event on the surface is often merely the hood ornament on the mighty social engine that is a story driving the culture. We call those “dominant narratives” or “paradigms” or “memes”^[1] or “metaphors we live by” or “frameworks”. However we describe them, they are immensely powerful forces. And the dominant culture mostly goes about reinforcing the stories that are the pillars propping it up and that, too often, are also the bars of someone else’s cage. They are too often stories that should be broken, or are already broken and ruined and ruinous and way past their expiration date. They sit atop mountains of unexamined assumptions . . .

Part of the job of a great storyteller is to examine the stories that underlie the story . . . to make them visible, and sometimes to break us free of them. Break the story. Breaking is a creative act as much as making . . .

REBECCA SOLNIT
Extract from *Break the Story*

^[1] memes *ideas, behaviours or styles that are symbolic and easily transmitted*

Call Them by Their True Names: American Crises (and Essays) (specifically *Break the Story*)
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The prescribed texts for Section II are:

◆ **Elective 1: Literary Homelands**

The prescribed texts are:

- **Prose Fiction** – Aravind Adiga, *The White Tiger*
– E M Forster, *A Passage to India*
– Colm Tóibín, *Brooklyn*
- **Poetry** – Eileen Chong, *Burning Rice*
The prescribed poems are:
 - * *Burning Rice*
 - * *Mid-autumn Mooncakes*
 - * *My Hakka Grandmother*
 - * *Shophouse, Victoria Street*
 - * *Chinese Ginseng*
 - * *Winter Meeting*
 - * *Singapore*
- **Drama** – Andrew Bovell, *The Secret River* [by Kate Grenville – An adaptation for the stage by Andrew Bovell]
- **Film** – Sarah Gavron, *Brick Lane*

Section II prescribed texts continue on page 6

The prescribed texts for Section II (continued)

◆ **Elective 2: Worlds of Upheaval**

The prescribed texts are:

- **Prose Fiction** – Elizabeth Gaskell, *North and South*
– Mary Shelley, *Frankenstein*
– Madeleine Thien, *Do Not Say We Have Nothing*
- **Poetry** – Seamus Heaney, *Opened Ground: Poems 1966–1996*
The prescribed poems are:
 - * *Digging*
 - * *The Strand at Lough Beg*
 - * *Casualty*
 - * *Funeral Rites*
 - * from *Whatever You Say Say Nothing*
 - * *Triptych*
- **Drama** – Samuel Beckett, *Waiting for Godot*
- **Film** – Fritz Lang, *Metropolis*

Section II prescribed texts continue on page 7

The prescribed texts for Section II (continued)

◆ **Elective 3: Reimagined Worlds**

The prescribed texts are:

- **Prose Fiction**
 - Italo Calvino, *If on a Winter's Night a Traveller*
 - Ursula Le Guin, *The Left Hand of Darkness*
 - Jonathan Swift, *Gulliver's Travels*
- **Poetry**
 - Samuel Taylor Coleridge, *Samuel Taylor Coleridge: The Complete Poems*

The prescribed poems are:

 - * *The Rime of the Ancient Mariner* (1834)
 - * *The Eolian Harp*
 - * *Kubla Khan*
 - * *Christabel*
 - Tracy K Smith, *Life on Mars*

The prescribed poems are:

 - * *Sci-Fi*
 - * *My God, It's Full of Stars*
 - * *Don't You Wonder, Sometimes?*
 - * *The Universe: Original Motion Picture Soundtrack*
 - * *The Universe as Primal Scream*
- **Film**
 - Guillermo Del Toro, *Pan's Labyrinth*

Section II prescribed texts continue on page 8

The prescribed texts for Section II (continued)

◆ **Elective 4: Literary Mindscapes**

The prescribed texts are:

- **Prose Fiction**
 - William Faulkner, *As I Lay Dying*
 - Gail Jones, *Sixty Lights*
 - Katherine Mansfield, *The Collected Stories*
 - * *Prelude*
 - * *Je ne Parle pas Français*
 - * *Bliss*
 - * *Psychology*
 - * *The Daughters of the Late Colonel*
- **Poetry**
 - Emily Dickinson, *The Complete Poems*

The prescribed poems are:

 - * *I felt a Funeral, in my Brain*
 - * *This is my letter to the World*
 - * *I died for Beauty – but was scarce*
 - * *I had been hungry, all the Years*
 - * *Because I could not stop for Death*
 - * *My Life had stood – a Loaded Gun*
 - * *A word dropped careless on a Page*
- **Drama**
 - William Shakespeare, *Hamlet*
- **Film**
 - Sofia Coppola, *Lost in Translation*

Section II prescribed texts continue on page 9

The prescribed texts for Section II (continued)

◆ **Elective 5: Intersecting Worlds**

The prescribed texts are:

- **Prose Fiction** – Melissa Harrison, *Clay*
– Alex Miller, *Journey to the Stone Country*
– Annie Proulx, *The Shipping News*
- **Nonfiction** – Tim Winton, *Island Home*
- **Poetry** – William Wordsworth, *William Wordsworth: The Major Works*

The prescribed poems are:

- * *Lines written a few miles above Tintern Abbey*
 - * *Three years she grew in sun and shower*
 - * *My heart leaps up when I behold*
 - * *Resolution and Independence*
 - * *The world is too much with us*
 - * *Ode ('There was a time')*
 - * *The Solitary Reaper*
 - * *The Prelude* (1805) – Book One, lines 1–67, 271–441
- **Film** – Daniel Nettheim, *The Hunter*

End of paper

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